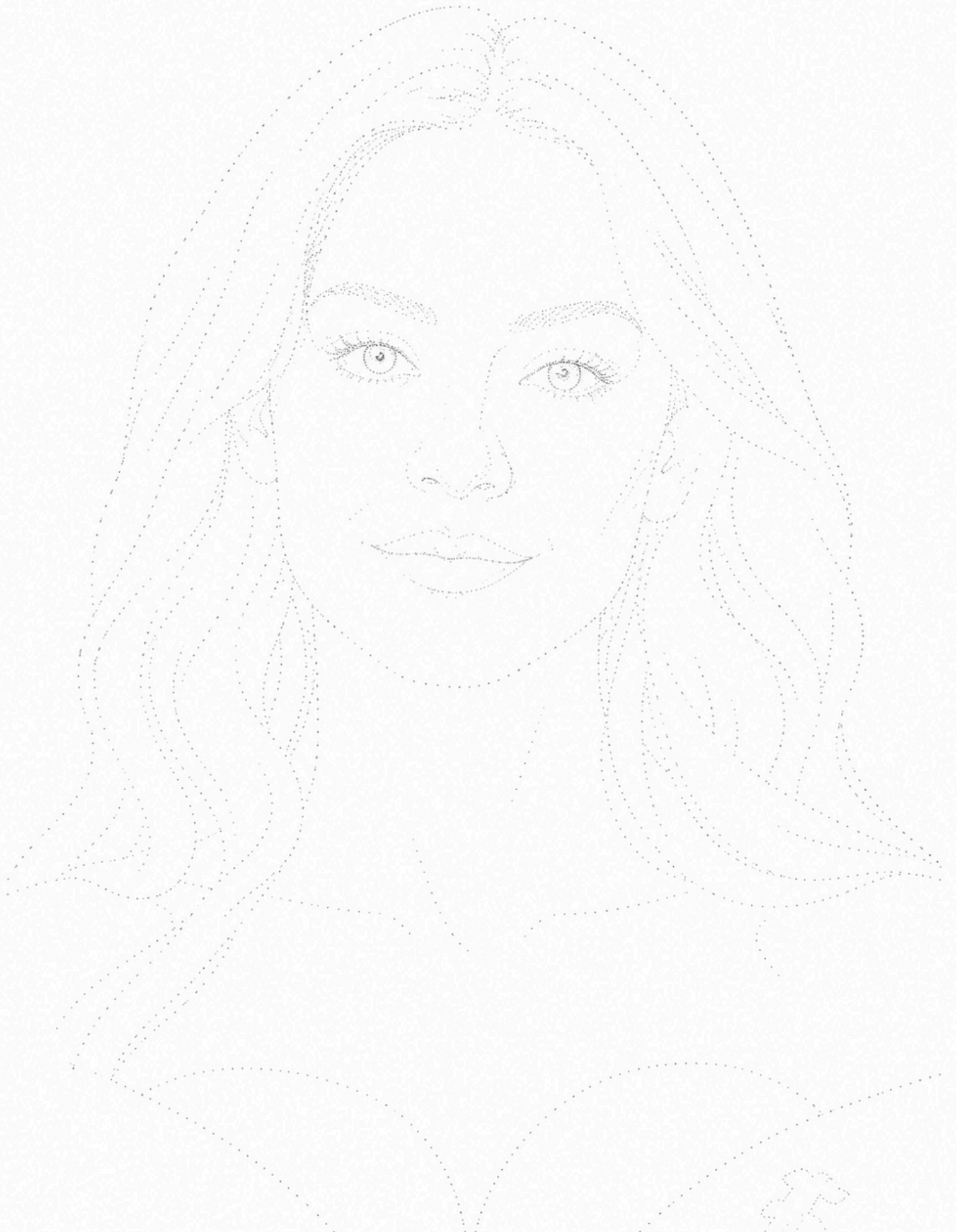


Line art — print at A4, 100% scale. Personal practice use.



Portrait Guide #020

Difficulty Advanced Est. time 10–14 hours

Subject A woman with long, loose, curly auburn-brown hair, soft downward gaze, peaceful serene expression, warm golden-olive skin tone, unclothed shoulders and upper chest, lit by warm diffuse light from front-upper left.

Pencils Prismacolor Premier

• MATERIALS

Two ways to work this guide. Every pencil number below is a Prismacolor Premier number — the 24 set covers the roles, the 150 set covers the exact numbers. Each step also names what its key pencil is *doing*, so a substitution never breaks the sequence.

Starting out

Prismacolor Premier Colored Pencils — Set of 24, Portrait Colors — the skin colors this guide uses (warm mid-light, cool dark, warm earth, saturated accent) all exist in the 24. Where a step or garment names a number you don't have, swatch with whatever you like or close.

Strathmore 300 Bristol, vellum surface, 9×12 — vellum tooth holds the layer counts below; smooth plate clogs in half the layers.

If you want the exact set-up

Prismacolor Premier, 150 set — every pencil number in this guide comes from this set, so nothing needs substituting.

Legion Stonehenge drawing paper — a softer, more forgiving tooth that takes more layers before it fills, and burnishes to a smoother finish.

Either way: kneaded eraser · electric eraser · a colorless blender. **No solvent** — every blend in this guide is dry.

• COLOR PALETTE



70% Warm Grey

PC1056

Value mapping foundation; warm-neutral monochrome base; optical mixing undertone for skin and background



Nectar

PC1092

Light red-orange skin undertone glaze; subsurface scattering and warm glow in lit planes



Peach Beige

PC1085

Warm mid-tone optical mixing on cheeks and mid-face; measured skin colour anchor



Beige Sienna

PC1080

Primary measured skin mid-tone for face, neck, and chest; warm local colour base



Henna

PC1031

Warm mid-value red-orange for shadows, hair mid-tones, and lip depth; chromatic shadow



Chestnut

PC1081

Dark warm red-orange for core shadows, hair structure, and neck self-shadow



Chocolate

PC1082

Very dark warm red-orange for hair base and deep shadow foundation



Cream

PC914

Near-white highlight and burnishing agent; peak highlights and light blending



Cloud Blue

PC1023

Cool light grey-blue for sclera and cool undertone in shadows (not pure white or grey)



Black

PC935

Pupils, upper lash line, deepest hair shadows, and punch-back darks after burnishing



Dark Brown

PC946

Very dark warm brown for hair deep shadows between curls; alternative to black



Bronze

PC1028

Warm mid-tone orange for hair glow and lit curl edges; subsurface warmth



Ginger Root

PC1084

Light warm golden-brown for hair highlights and warm light-catching edges



10% Warm Grey

PC1050

Cool warm-grey undertone overlay for neck and chest texture; subtle cool in shadows and edges



Light Peach

PC927

Warm light base for lower lip; catches light and reads luminous



Seashell Pink

PC1093

Soft warm pink for lower lip base and warm undertone



Deco Pink

PC1014

Cool mid-value pink for upper lip; darker and cooler than lower lip



Periwinkle

PC1025

Cool blue-violet for iris overlay; creates luminosity through warm-cool optical mixing



White

PC938

Peak specular highlights on forehead, nose, cheekbones; final bright accents

• VISUAL ANALYSIS

LIGHT & SHADOW ANALYSIS

Light source direction

Warm, diffuse light from upper-front-left; soft quality creates gradual transitions and visible subsurface scattering in vascular zones (nose, cheeks, ears)

HIGHLIGHT

Forehead dome apex, bridge of nose, tip of nose, cheekbone peaks, center of upper chest; warm and bright but never pure white

LIGHT AREA

Upper forehead, upper half of cheeks, center of face, front of neck, center of chest

MIDTONE

Lower cheeks, sides of face, most of the neck, sides of chest, transitional zones around the jaw

SHADOW

Under the jaw (soft self-shadow), shadow-side cheekbone plane, upper eyelid cavity, sides of the neck, around the nostril

CAST SHADOW

Soft self-shadow directly under the chin and jaw line; no sharp cast shadow, only a gradual transition to midtone

Edge quality notes

Soft, diffuse light creates gentle, rounded terminators rather than crisp edges; subsurface scattering visible as warm glow in cheeks and nose; the cheekbone plane has a slightly sharper terminator where it turns from light to shadow, but still soft overall; hair catches light on outer edges with soft halos

• STEP-BY-STEP INSTRUCTIONS

OI Step 1: Value Map — Monochrome Foundation

Full face, neck, and upper chest

Light-pressure circular strokes; monochrome value mapping; gradual terminator

Light pressure

- Value carries form; colour is secondary. Colored pencil does not lift, so establish the FULL range (peak light to deepest shadow) now in monochrome, at light pressure, preserving paper tooth for the layers still to come. A compressed value range reads flat no matter how accurate the colours.
- Using light pressure and circular strokes with PC1056 70% Warm Grey, block the entire lit hemisphere (forehead, nose, upper cheeks, upper chest) at approximately 40% value. Work in small circles, maintaining even coverage. The goal is to establish the local mid-tone and anchor your light reference.
- Darken the shadow planes (lower cheeks, sides of jaw, under the jaw line, shadow-side neck) to approximately 50–60% value with the same pencil, still at light pressure, still circular. The terminator (the edge where light meets shadow) should be gradual, not a hard line—this gradual transition is what makes the cheekbone read as round.
- Place deepest darks (upper eyelid shadows, nostril cavity, the self-shadow directly under the jaw, the core of the hair if visible) at 70–80% value, using light pressure and avoiding any maximum-pressure black. These anchor your range without crushing paper tooth.
- Step back: you should see clear form separation between lit and shadow sides, a defined jaw plane, a rounded cheek, and three-dimensional head structure, all in grey alone. No blown-out highlights, no crushing blacks.

COLORS ● PC1056 70% Warm Grey

↔ PC1056 70% Warm Grey is doing warm-neutral mid-grey value mapping; PC1050 10% Warm Grey (slightly lighter) or PC1072 50% French Grey work identically for this monochrome stage. Do not use a cool grey alone—warm grey keeps the foundation warm for the skin tones to follow.

STOP WHEN

The lit planes read 40–50% value, shadows 70–80%, with a gradual curve between them · the pencil is gliding freely on paper, not dragging, and paper texture is visibly preserved where you want it

✦ *This pass is a map, not a finish. Do not add black to shadows yet—a warm grey reaching 70–80% is darker than it looks, and black-grey reads dead. You will layer colour over this structure; rushing to darkness now wastes the tooth you need for the layers ahead.*

02 Step 2: Skin Undertones and Base Colour — Optical Mixing Foundation

Full face and upper neck

Optical mixing via thin transparent glazes; light-pressure circular strokes; subsurface-scattering logic

Light pressure

- Skin is translucent: light enters, bounces inside, and exits nearby, creating a warm glow in thin or vascular zones. Layer the FIRST colour pass in warm undertones BEFORE you darken with local colour. This is optical mixing—thin layers fusing in the eye into one luminous colour, never mixed on paper into mud.
- FIRST PASS: Using very light pressure and circular strokes, glaze PC1092 Nectar (light red-orange) across the entire face as a warm undertone. Work around the eye sockets and under the nose without filling the deepest shadows; the goal is a warm glow across all lit and midtone planes. This mimics subsurface scattering and establishes luminosity.
- SECOND PASS (once the first feels set and tooth is still visible): Layer PC1085 Peach Beige over the mid-face—cheeks, bridge of nose, forehead dome. Peach Beige is lighter and warmer than Nectar. In the eye, Nectar + Peach Beige fuses into a rich warm mid-tone without the muddy thickness of one heavy pencil. Use light pressure in small circles.
- Add PC1080 Beige Sienna (the measured skin mid-tone) into the cheek zones at light-pressure circular strokes, slightly overlapping the Peach Beige. This begins local colour without committing to deep value—still transparent, still building.
- Warm the nose tip slightly with a few light strokes of PC1092 Nectar on the tip only: the nose is thin and vascular, so it glows warm even in shadow, brighter than surrounding planes.

COLORS  PC1092 Nectar  PC1085 Peach Beige  PC1080 Beige Sienna

↔ PC1092 Nectar (light red-orange undertone) is done by PC1001 Salmon Pink or PC927 Light Peach—any light warm red-orange. PC1085 Peach Beige (warm mid-tone glaze) is done by PC939 Peach or PC1019 Rosy Beige. PC1080 Beige Sienna (measured skin mid-tone) is optimal but can be approximated with PC997 Beige or PC1085 Peach Beige if Sienna is unavailable.

STOP WHEN

The face reads as a warm peachy-golden tone, lighter in lit planes, and tooth is still visibly preserved across the whole zone · you can count individual pencil strokes and see paper texture throughout, not a smooth blend

✦ *This stage is the soul of the portrait. A warm, thin, luminous foundation makes skin GLOW. Every portrait master does this layering; every rushed beginner skips it and*

gets plastic-looking skin. Commit to thin layers and optical mixing here; your portrait's luminosity depends on it.

03 Step 3: Skin Mid-tones and Shadow Depth — Form and Plane Separation

Full face and upper neck, particularly shadow planes

Warm shadow layering; crisp terminator edge on shadow-side plane; optical blending; colourless-blender smoothing

Light to Medium pressure

- The value map set the range; now deepen the midtones and shadows with LOCAL COLOUR while keeping WARM TEMPERATURES. Warm shadows stay chromatic—olive, sienna, rust—never ashy or neutral grey. The away-side (shadow) cheekbone plane must show ONE crisp core-shadow edge where it turns from light; this edge makes the head read as solid three-dimensional form, not a flat face.
- In the lit planes (forehead dome, upper cheeks, center of face), layer PC1080 Beige Sienna at light-to-medium pressure in circular strokes to build saturation and depth. The eye should see rich local colour emerging, still warm, still luminous—this is NOT darkening yet, just enriching the hue.
- On the shadow-side cheekbone and jaw (the plane that faces away from light), deepen with PC1031 Henna (warm mid-value red-orange) at light-pressure circular strokes. This plane must be noticeably cooler and darker than the lit cheek but STILL WARM and opaque. At the terminator—where the cheekbone turns from light to shadow—sharpen the edge slightly by placing one final crisp stroke of Henna along that line. This single sharp edge is what makes the cheekbone TURN convincingly in three dimensions.
- Layer PC1081 Chestnut into core shadow zones: under the jaw, the deepest part of the cheek shadow, along the side of the nose, into the upper eyelid. Use light pressure; shadows deepen gradually across many passes, never punched in heavy.
- Blend very lightly across the terminator zone with a colourless blender at light pressure, or a very light stroke of PC914 Cream. This softens the hard terminator edge just slightly while preserving its sharpness; the transition reads organic rather than painted.

COLORS

● PC1080 Beige Sienna

● PC1031 Henna

● PC1081 Chestnut

● PC914 Cream

↔ PC1031 Henna (warm shadow mid-tone) is done by PC1029 Mahogany Red, PC1017 Clay Rose, or PC1019 Rosy Beige. PC1081 Chestnut (warm dark) is done by PC1082 Chocolate or PC947 Dark Umber. Colourless blender is done by PC914 Cream or PC927 Light Peach at ultra-light pressure.

STOP WHEN

Shadow planes read as warm mid-value (brown-toned, not grey), the terminator edge is crisp on the shadow-side cheekbone, and the colourless blender is sliding without

dragging · the away-side plane is clearly darker and cooler than the lit cheek but still visibly warm in colour

✦ *The AWAY-SIDE plane is the commonest failure: made too soft (no form), too dark (murky), or too cool (ashy, like a bruise). Give it ONE sharp terminator edge and keep it MID-WARM in colour—not the same as the lit side, but not a dead dark either. This single plane is what makes or breaks the 3D read of the entire head.*

04 Step 4: Eyes — Spherical Form and Specular Light

Both eyes

Spherical form building; radial iris strokes; asymmetric upper/lower lash contrast; peak highlight as final accent

Medium throughout, Heavy only for specular highlight pressure

- Eyes are transparent spheres with a dark pupil window; the sclera is never pure white, the iris is never flat, and the upper lid casts a shadow that makes the eye recede into the skull. Build in this order to lock depth: pupil → upper-lid shadow → sclera tone → iris with radial strokes → asymmetric lash lines → specular highlight LAST.
- Block the pupil of each eye with PC935 Black at medium pressure, a small circle slightly off-center toward the inner corner (pupils sit nasal, not centered). The upper eyelid shadow falls over the top of the pupil as a curved dark stroke of PC935 Black, darker where it meets the pupil and easing toward the outer corner. This shadow is what gives the eye depth; without it the eye reads flat.
- Fill the sclera (white of the eye) with PC1024 Cloud Blue at very light pressure in small contained strokes. Cloud Blue is cool light grey-blue, not pure white—this makes the eye feel moist and alive. Leave one tiny speck undrawn for the specular highlight; you will add it in the final pass.
- Layer the iris with PC1031 Henna in radial strokes from the pupil outward (like spokes), using medium pressure. This warm undertone makes the iris glow. Then glaze PC1025 Periwinkle over the iris at light pressure—a cool blue-violet over warm red creates luminosity through colour contrast. The radial strokes prove the iris is a sphere catching light; do NOT make a flat fill.
- The upper lash line is the DARKEST DARK in the eye area: stroke PC935 Black along the upper lid margin, crisp and slightly thicker than the lower. The lower lashes stay soft and diffuse—a few light strokes of PC1050 10% Warm Grey or PC1024 Cloud Blue, never as dark. This asymmetry makes eyes look awake and dimensional.
- Lift the specular highlight LAST: a single bright white point where light reflects (usually upper-inner, where pupil and iris meet), using PC938 White at medium-to-heavy pressure. One bright jewel-like point is more powerful than a large soft highlight.

COLORS

● PC935 Black

● PC1023 Cloud Blue

● PC1031 Henna

● PC1025 Periwinkle

● PC1050 10% Warm Grey

● PC938 White

↔ PC935 Black (pupils and dark lash) is done by PC1099 Espresso or PC1024 Cloud Blue (softer). PC1024 Cloud Blue (sclera) is done by PC1087 Powder Blue or PC1023 Cloud Blue. PC1031 Henna (iris warm) is done by PC1014 Deco Pink or PC1001 Salmon Pink. PC1025

Periwinkle (iris cool) has no true substitute; PC1027 Peacock Blue or PC1079 Blue Violet Lake shift colour but work.

STOP WHEN

Iris shows visible radial strokes and two-colour layering (warm red + cool blue), upper lash is crisp and dark, lower lash is soft and diffuse, sclera reads cool grey-blue not white, and the specular highlight is one bright point · you have used white at full pressure once in one tiny spot only, not revisited it

✦ *Radial iris strokes are not a detail—they are proof of form. A flat iris reads painted-on; radial strokes read as a sphere catching light. Spend 20 strokes on each iris; most artists spend two and wonder why eyes are dead. This one technique is what separates amateur from advanced.*

05 Step 5: Lips — Temperature and Light-Catching Form

Upper and lower lips

Form-based layering; warm core shadow; soft integrated lip line; creases at ultra-light pressure

Light to Medium, Ultra-Light for line and creases pressure

- Lips are a form plane: the upper lip faces slightly inward and sits in shadow (darker, cooler), the lower lip catches direct light (brighter, warmer). Build form through value and temperature, never with a hard outline. A lip line drawn as an outline reads as a bad tattoo; an integrated lip line reads as alive.
- Base the upper lip with PC1014 Deco Pink at light pressure in circular strokes. This cool mid-value pink establishes the upper lip as the darker, cooler of the two. Keep it light—you will deepen it next pass.
- Base the lower lip with PC927 Light Peach at light pressure. The lower lip catches light directly, so it reads lighter and warmer than the upper. This warm peachy tone is more saturated and reflective.
- Layer the center of the lower lip (the brightest zone) with PC1080 Beige Sienna at light pressure. This deepens the colour and adds richness without dulling the light-catching form. The lower lip now reads as a lit plane: lighter, warmer, more saturated than the upper.
- Darken the upper lip with PC926 Carmine Red at light-to-medium pressure, layering into the mid-line where the two lips meet. This is the core shadow of the upper lip—the zone facing away from light. Keep it WARM (red or mahogany, never purple or grey).
- Add the lip line with one very light stroke of PC1031 Henna along the upper-lower parting at ultra-light pressure—just enough to suggest the edge, not a drawn outline. In the center of the lower lip where light is brightest, a faint stroke of PC914 Cream integrated into the peachy base suggests the catch light.
- Add fine horizontal creases with PC1050 10% Warm Grey at very light pressure using a sharp point—just 2–3 fine lines across the lower lip, barely visible on close inspection. These creases keep lips from looking like a smooth painted patch.

COLORS ● PC1014 Deco Pink ● PC927 Light Peach ● PC1080 Beige Sienna
● PC926 Carmine Red ● PC1031 Henna ● PC914 Cream
● PC1050 10% Warm Grey

↔ PC1014 Deco Pink (cool upper lip) is done by PC1025 Periwinkle or PC1026 Greyed Lavender. PC927 Light Peach (warm lower lip base) is done by PC939 Peach or PC1013 Deco Peach. PC926 Carmine Red (upper lip depth) is done by PC925 Crimson Lake or PC1029 Mahogany Red. PC1031 Henna (lip line) is done by PC1050 10% Warm Grey.

STOP WHEN

Upper lip reads cooler and darker than lower, lower lip has a light catch and reads as a form plane, the lip line is soft and integrated (not outlined), and creases are visible only on close inspection · when viewed at arm's length the crease lines almost disappear, and the lip line is suggested by colour, not drawn

✦ *The lip line is the hardest line on the entire face to NOT draw, yet drawing it kills the portrait. Integrate it by layering warm and cool colours into the parting rather than outlining. A lip outline reads as a bad tattoo; integrated lips read alive and real. This is advanced lip technique: integrate first, outline never.*

06 Step 6: Hair — Long Curly Loose Structure, Base Through Highlights

Long curly loose hair

Layered mass structure; pressure gradient (heavy at roots, easing toward tips); full-length strokes following curl direction; placed (not drawn) shadows between curls; warm highlights on lit edges only

Medium for base; Medium-Heavy for shadows and roots; Light to Medium for warm tones; Light for highlights pressure

- Hair is NOT one flat value or one colour; it is a transparent mass of individual strands with light passing through some and shadow pooling in others. For LONG CURLY HAIR, the strategy is: (1) establish dense dark masses at roots and between curls, (2) follow each curl's curve with full-length strokes from dark roots easing lighter toward tips, (3) preserve light between curls by keeping tooth clean there until the final pass. The eye reads curls from VALUE CONTRAST between dark core and bright edge, NOT from drawn lines.
- FIRST PASS—BASE AND ROOT DENSITY: Using medium pressure and following growth direction from crown down, block the hair base with PC1082 Chocolate. Establish the darkest root area at the crown with heavier layers, then ease pressure as you stroke downward—the pencil should taper from heavy (roots) to light (tips), mimicking how real hair thins from root to end. Work AROUND the face; do not fill the entire page. Goal: warm dark foundation defining curl volumes.
- SECOND PASS—SHADOWS BETWEEN CURLS AND DENSITY GRADIENT: Once the first layer feels set, place PC935 Black or PC946 Dark Brown in the deep VALLEYS BETWEEN curls and in the core hair mass where light does not reach. These are NOT strokes down the hair—they are placed DELIBERATELY in the shadows between curl forms. Use medium pressure; do not fill the entire mass. This pass creates STRUCTURE: the contrast between lit curl edges and dark valleys reads as 3D curls. Also deepen the roots with PC946 Dark Brown at medium-heavy pressure, building density where hair emerges from scalp.
- THIRD PASS—WARM MID-TONES AND GLOW: Layer PC1031 Henna or PC1028 Bronze (warm mid-tones) into the LIT CURVES of curls, following full-length strokes from root to tip. These sit over the Chocolate base but NOT in the deepest shadows—they sit on the curve catching light. Use light-to-medium pressure following the contour of each curl. The eye sees Chocolate + Henna as rich warm-brown, luminous.
- FOURTH PASS—HIGHLIGHTS AND SHEEN: Use PC1084 Ginger Root or PC1080 Beige Sienna for very light warm highlights where light is BRIGHTEST on curl edges. These are thin strokes placed ONLY on the lit outer edge of curls—never through shadows. Ginger Root is warm golden-brown, not blonde—a warm glow on dark hair. Stroke along visible curl edges where light catches, at light pressure. This is the final mid-tone pass; stop before over-working.

- TIP: Curly hair reads DIMENSIONAL from value contrast and edge placement, NOT from carefully drawn individual strands. A common mistake is outlining every curl—this makes hair look like a wig. Instead: dark core, light edge, varied values between them. Let some curls be half-visible in shadow, let others emerge as bright curves. The AUDIENCE'S EYE completes the curl structure; you provide value contrast.

COLORS

● PC1082 Chocolate

● PC946 Dark Brown

● PC935 Black

● PC1031 Henna

● PC1028 Bronze

● PC1084 Ginger Root

● PC1080 Beige Sienna

↔ PC1082 Chocolate (base) is done by PC1081 Chestnut or PC947 Dark Umber. PC935 Black (deepest shadows) is done by PC946 Dark Brown or PC1099 Espresso. PC1031 Henna (warm mid-tone) is done by PC1028 Bronze or PC1084 Ginger Root. PC1084 Ginger Root (highlights) is done by PC1080 Beige Sienna or PC1028 Bronze—these warm reddish-browns, not yellow or blonde.

STOP WHEN

Dark masses are visible at roots and between curls, light is preserved on outer curl edges, and warm tones glow on lit curves; the overall effect is a 3D curl mass, not a flat patch · your pencil is following curves and easing pressure from root to tip, and you are resisting the urge to outline individual curls

✦ *Curly hair is NOT wavy—waves are flat undulations, curls are spirals turning in 3D space. Each visible curl should show a turn: dark on one side (away from light), light on the other (lit edge), and a transition between. If curls look flat or wig-like, you're working too uniformly. Break the hair into separate masses (3–4 large curl groups), give each its own dark core and bright edge, vary values within each so no two curls read the same. The eye will construct the curly form from this variation alone.*

07 Step 7: Neck and Chest — Form, Self-Shadow, Texture, and Temperature

Full neck and upper chest

Subtle texture via varied pressure and direction; soft self-shadow under jaw; cool undertone overlay; texture emphasis over smoothness

Light to Medium, varied for texture effect pressure

- The neck and chest anchor the head to the body and show light, form, and temperature just like the face. The neck is a cylinder lit from above; it casts a soft self-shadow under the jaw and sits in the warm light—expect the neck to be COOLER in colour than the face, slightly more olive, and to show a gradual warmth shift from face to neck. TEXTURE here is CRUCIAL: subtle grain and minor irregularities read as REAL SKIN. Do not smooth this zone to plastic perfection.
- Using light pressure and circular strokes, base the neck with PC1080 Beige Sienna (the same measured skin mid-tone as the face), but apply it in SLIGHTLY COOLER, MORE MUTED strokes than on the face—do NOT layer Nectar or Peach Beige underneath as heavily. The neck should feel cooler and less saturated than the cheek; the eye should SEE a gradual warmth shift from face down to neck. Work around the self-shadow area without filling it yet.
- Establish the self-shadow under the jaw with PC1031 Henna or PC1081 Chestnut—a soft band of shadow where the chin occludes light, wrapping under the sides of the jaw. Use light pressure following the natural curve under the chin; this shadow is softer than face core shadows but clearly darker than lit neck. This is NOT a hard outline but a gentle transition reading as the jaw sitting above the neck.
- Layer PC1050 10% Warm Grey into neck zones to create a cooler, more olive undertone compared to the warmer face. Use light-to-medium pressure in small circles or varied-direction strokes, building texture and subtle unevenness—real skin is not uniformly smooth. Introduce minor variations in pressure and stroke direction to suggest subtle texture (pores, minor irregularities, barely-visible skin grain). This is where the TEXTURE emphasis pays off: a uniform neck looks fake; a subtly varied neck reads real.
- The chest, where visible, follows the same logic as the neck but is even cooler and sits in more general light. Base the visible chest area with PC1080 Beige Sienna at light pressure, then glaze PC1050 10% Warm Grey or PC1056 70% Warm Grey at very light pressure to cool it and add texture. The chest should appear the same face tone but noticeably cooler and slightly more matt (less direct light, less subsurface glow).
- Strengthen the self-shadow on the chest if any anatomical shadow exists (e.g., below collarbone if visible). Use PC1081 Chestnut or PC1031 Henna at light-to-medium pressure, keeping the edge soft and the shadow mid-warm rather than dark. Goal: form through value and temperature, not hard carved shadow.

- **TIP: TEMPERATURE IS FORM HERE.** The face glows warm because it is rounded, thin-skinned, vascular. The neck and chest are cooler, more olive, because they are flatter and farther from face centre. Keeping neck and chest **NOTICEABLY** cooler than the face makes the face POP as the focal area while making the entire head-and-neck form read convincingly 3D. Many artists make the neck the same temperature as the face, which flattens form.

COLORS

● PC1080 Beige Sienna

● PC1031 Henna

● PC1081 Chestnut

● PC1050 10% Warm Grey

● PC1056 70% Warm Grey

↔ PC1080 Beige Sienna (base) is done by PC997 Beige or PC1085 Peach Beige. PC1031 Henna and PC1081 Chestnut (shadows) are done by PC1029 Mahogany Red, PC1017 Clay Rose, or PC1019 Rosy Beige. PC1050 10% Warm Grey (cool texture overlay) is done by PC1051 20% Warm Grey or PC1052 30% Warm Grey, or very light PC1056 70% Warm Grey.

STOP WHEN

The neck and chest show clear value separation (lit planes lighter, self-shadow under jaw darker), the tone is noticeably cooler than the face, and the surface shows subtle texture variation rather than flat smoothness · you are varying stroke direction and pressure slightly to create minor irregularities reading as skin texture, and the jaw shadow is soft and integrated, not a hard line

✦ *Skin texture is not a detail—it is the difference between a portrait and a painting. You earn this by varying stroke direction every few strokes, randomizing pressure slightly within the zone, and RESISTING perfect blending. A neck with subtle grain reads as skin; a perfectly smooth neck reads as plastic. This zone rewards SUBTLETY and pays off enormously in realism. The artist emphasized this area for good reason: invest time here.*

08 Step 8: Edge Hierarchy and Feature Definition — Focal Accent and Recession

Lash lines, feature edges, outer contours, silhouette

Hard edge on focal accent (lash line); progressively softer edges moving outward; lost edges into background; soft feature definition

Medium-Heavy on lash line; progressively lighter outward pressure

- In colored pencil, HARD EDGES advance and grab the eye; SOFT EDGES recede. The focal accent—the feature drawing the viewer's attention first—gets the SHARPEST edge; all other edges gradually soften and LOSE into the background as you move outward. This hierarchy is what makes a portrait feel dimensionally convincing and keeps viewer attention where intended. Without edge hierarchy, the entire portrait reads flat and equally important everywhere.
- The focal accent on most faces is the UPPER LASH LINE where eyelids meet irises. Sharpen this edge now: reinforce the dark line of PC935 Black (or PC1099 Espresso) along the upper lash margin with medium-to-heavy pressure, so it reads crisp and dark. This is the SINGLE SHARPEST EDGE on the entire portrait. Every other edge must be SOFTER than this.
- The lower lash line stays soft and diffuse: if visible, keep it light grey or warm undertone, never hard definition. Upper lashes catch light; lower lashes face slightly away. This asymmetry is what makes eyes look awake.
- SOFTEN THE JAW AND CHIN edges into neck and shadow: the jaw is the second-most-defined edge on the face (after the lash line), but it must be SOFTER than the lash line. Use light-pressure strokes of PC1081 Chestnut or PC1050 10% Warm Grey along the jaw edge to suggest form without a hard outline. Let the jaw fade into neck shadow; do NOT draw a hard line.
- ACTIVELY LOSE edges outward: the sides of the face where it meets background (temples, sides of jaw, outer cheeks) should gradually fade and LOSE into background. Use light pressure and ease pressure further moving outward, so edges become softer and hazier as they move away from the lash line. Some hairs should drift into background; some face contours barely suggested. This is CONTROL of viewer attention.
- Refine nose edges: the bridge reads against a forehead plane (usually one value lighter), so a subtle soft edge here suggests form. Nostril sides should remain soft; never outline with a hard line. The nose tip is fuller and rounder; value separation (lighter tip, slightly darker sides) reads as roundness without edge.
- Lip line: integrate fully—never a hard outline. Use warm and cool layers already placed to suggest where one lip ends and the other begins, not a drawn line.

COLORS

 PC935 Black

 PC1099 Espresso

 PC1081 Chestnut

 PC1050 10% Warm Grey

↔ PC935 Black (lash line) is done by PC1099 Espresso or PC1024 Cloud Blue. PC1081 Chestnut and PC1050 10% Warm Grey (soft feature edges) are done by similar warm and cool mid-greys, or very light PC1056 70% Warm Grey.

STOP WHEN

The upper lash line is crisp and dark and stands out from every other edge; the lower lash is soft and diffuse; the jaw edge is softer than the lash line but still definable; the sides of the face fade into the background · you can name the focal accent and every other edge is clearly softer than it

✦ *Edge hierarchy is the most misunderstood advanced technique: most artists make EVERY edge equally hard, creating a flat, amateur feel. Spend 2 minutes identifying the sharpest edge you want (usually the lash line), make it UNMISTAKABLY sharp, then make every other edge demonstrably softer. This alone elevates a portrait's realism and keeps the viewer's eye where you want it.*

09 Step 9: Background and Lost Edges — Grounding the Figure in Space

Negative space; outer contours of figure; silhouette

Light-pressure even field; strategic lost edges; preservation of focal-side silhouette; soft transitions

Light pressure

- The background is NOT empty space—it is a lit form that grounds the figure in space and controls the silhouette. A completely blank background (white paper) makes the head float; a deliberately chosen background tone makes the figure sit in light. Because this portrait has no garment, the background is MORE important to composition—it is the only context besides hair and neck.
- Choose a warm-neutral background tone: PC1056 70% Warm Grey or PC1050 10% Warm Grey, applied at light pressure in a relatively even field. Do NOT blend in visible brushwork or texture; let it stay quiet and supportive, darker than the lit face but lighter than deep hair shadows. Goal: a neutral warm field that lets the figure read against it without competing.
- Deliberately LOSE at least one silhouette edge into the background: apply background tone over part of the hair edge (perhaps one side of head) so hair and background merge in places. This loss of edge is NOT a mistake—it is a deliberate technique making the figure sit in space rather than float on top. Choose one side; do not lose edges everywhere or the head becomes ambiguous.
- Sharpen the opposite silhouette edge: where you have lost one side into background, ensure the OTHER side of the head (often the far side from focal accent) reads clearly against the background. The contrast between a lost edge and a sharp edge creates depth and composition.
- If any part of the hair catches bright light and is lighter than background, ensure that zone stays visible and defined. The lit edge of curly hair (often the outer curve on the lit side) should POP against a slightly darker or cooler background.
- Soften the background-to-figure transition: do NOT paint a hard line between background and figure. Let background tone fade with decreasing pressure as it approaches the figure, so the transition feels soft and atmospheric rather than painted on a backdrop.

COLORS ☒ PC1056 70% Warm Grey ☐ PC1050 10% Warm Grey

↔ PC1056 70% Warm Grey or PC1050 10% Warm Grey (background) can be any neutral grey: PC1072 50% French Grey, PC1069 20% French Grey, or even PC1074 70% French Grey if cooler. Avoid pure white paper (instant flatness) or heavy black (graphic, not atmospheric).

STOP WHEN

The background reads as a quiet neutral tone; at least one silhouette edge is lost into background; the opposite edge is preserved and visible; the background-figure

boundary is soft and atmospheric · the background does not compete with face for attention, and the figure reads as sitting in space, not floating on paper

✦ *A thoughtfully chosen background makes or breaks composition. Many artists render a perfect face and ignore the background, leaving white paper—instant flatness. 10 minutes on the background pays enormous dividends in overall portrait quality and the figure's sense of sitting in light.*

IO Step 10: Final Burnish and Peak Highlights — Surface Unification and Luminosity

Full portrait, emphasis on peak highlights and wax-bloom correction

Burnishing for surface unity; wax bloom removal; value punch-back; peak highlights as final accents; optional texture restoration

Heavy for burnishing; Medium-Heavy for punch-back darks; Heavy for peak highlights; Ultra-Light for optional texture pressure

- Burnishing melts all layers into a painted surface and locks pigment, but it also LIFTS wax as a hazy bloom and LIGHTENS values. The final pass is therefore BURNISH LAST, not first. Burnish only the finishing pass, then immediately PUNCH BACK the deepest darks that were lightened. This is non-optional.
- Using a colourless blender or PC914 Cream at HEAVY pressure, burnish the finished face and neck in broad circular strokes. This melts all the layers you have built into a unified, painted, luminous surface. You should see colours fuse (no individual pencil strokes visible), and any remaining white paper tooth should disappear. Burnish only FACE and NECK; leave hair and background lightly textured (do not burnish hair—it loses texture and looks plastic when over-blended).
- Immediately after burnishing (while wax is still slightly warm), wipe the surface gently with a soft cloth or tissue to remove the hazy wax bloom migrated to the surface. Do NOT scrub; a gentle pass is enough. Bloom removal keeps colours from looking washed out and chalky.
- Punch back the deepest darks: now that burnishing has lifted shadow values, re-darken the pupil, upper lash line, and any core shadows in the face that need depth. Use PC935 Black or PC1099 Espresso at medium-to-heavy pressure, placing fresh strokes ONLY in areas needing resetting. This is a REQUIRED step; do not skip it.
- Add peak highlights with PC938 White or PC914 Cream at heavy pressure in ONLY the brightest spots: forehead dome apex, bridge of nose, nose tip, cheekbone peaks, possibly the upper lip center where light catches. These are NOT large areas—each is a small, bright, hard edge reading as a light specular reflection. Place deliberately and sparingly; ten small highlights are more convincing than a large washed-out glow.
- Optional final texture: if the burnished face feels too smooth and plastic, add a TINY amount of texture back by lightly dragging a fine-point pencil (PC1050 10% Warm Grey at ultra-light pressure) in random directions across cheeks and forehead. This restores a hint of skin texture to an otherwise too-smooth surface. Do this sparingly.

- Step back and assess: the portrait should read as a unified, luminous painting with clear value separation between lit and shadow, warm tones throughout, and a focal accent drawing the eye. If it does not, the most likely issue is compressed values (not enough light-to-dark range) or muddy mid-tones (too many layers in one spot). Both are lessons for the next portrait—this one is complete.

COLORS

● PC914 Cream

● PC935 Black

● PC1099 Espresso

● PC938 White

● PC1050 10% Warm Grey

↔ PC914 Cream (burnishing) is done by PC938 White (harsher, may whiten too much) or a colourless blender (softer, more transparent). PC935 Black (punch-back darks) is done by PC1099 Espresso. PC938 White (peak highlights) is done by PC914 Cream (warmer, less bright).

STOP WHEN

Burnishing has created a painted, luminous surface with no visible paper tooth · the bloom has been wiped and colours read clear and not chalky · punch-back darks are as dark as the original layering (you can see them re-set) · peak highlights are bright, small, and crisp · the overall portrait reads as a finished, unified painting

✦ *Burnishing is NOT a soft blend—it is a heavy-pressure MELT into a painted surface. Many artists fear heavy pressure, but burnishing REQUIRES it. If your burnish does not feel like pressure, you have not actually burnished; the surface will still show tooth and layers. Commit to the pressure. And ALWAYS punch back darks after burnishing; this is non-optional. Burnishing is the last step because colored pencil does not erase, and this final pass locks everything in. The portrait is now complete.*

• WHEN YOU FINISH IT

Leave a comment under the video with a photo of your drawing. I'll run it through the same three lines the AI runs on mine — the verdict, the one thing to fix, and what to target next.

Free. I read all of them, and the ones I answer go in the comments so everyone else can see the same correction.